



players as a No. 9 in some of his matches, such as Manvir Singh against Syria in the Asian Cup and even Vikram against Afghanistan in the away game of the FIFA World Cup qualifiers.

But both these players haven't started a single game as a striker for their respective clubs.

Manvir plays as a winger or a

wing-back for Mohun Bagan.

The way forward

Stimac has admitted that he follows the ISL while India's assistant coach, Mahesh Gawli, looks after players from lower leagues.

Unless the ISL clubs deploy Indians as strikers, it becomes an uphill task for a national team head

Strike force: Parthib Gogoi has nine goals and an assist in all competitions this season for NorthEast United FC (NEUFC). FSDL/ISL MEDIA

coach to identify a striker and expect goals from him.

But for club coaches to do so, they would need the right balance between giving local talent opportunities to shine and having players who can play full games and score goals.

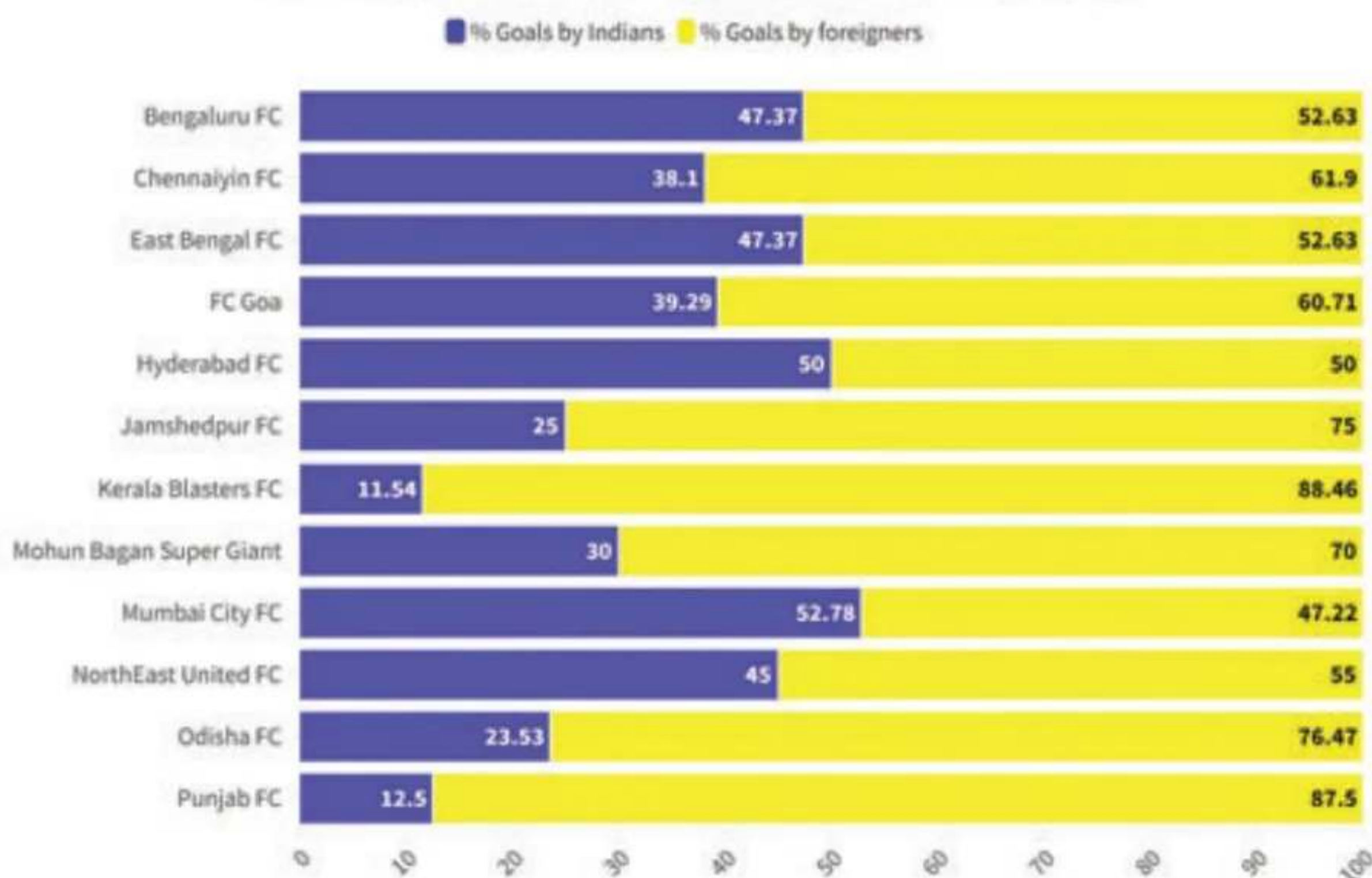
Though the list of Indian midfielders and wingers scoring in ISL is a long one, if the goalscorers alone, who are already conventional forwards, are compared for the sake of the problem statement of finding strikers, a few names pop up.

Chhetri and Chhangte dominate understandably, leading the national team's attack regularly under Stimac, but five other names make it to the list as well, considering the goal-scoring ability.

Bipin, though being a menace along the wings, is 29, while Sivasakthi Narayanan, once touted as the next No. 9 of India, is "no longer the player he used to be", according to Stimac, after his injury in the ISL final last year.

While Rahim has found the net a few times in the league, his poor finishing and inconsistency have

Team-wise breakdown of goalscorers in ISL 2023-24



Source: FBREF, Opta • All data in the article is till the ISL match Odisha FC vs Punjab FC on April 2, 2024